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Nebuchadnezzar

The proud king of Babylon who destroyed Jerusalem and learned that "the most High ruleth."

Nebuchadnezzar, Babylon's greatest king, carried Judah into exile. He besieged Jerusalem three times, took its young nobles to Babylon, and at last burned the temple. Jeremiah calls him God's "servant," a tool of judgment on a nation that would not turn back. Yet Daniel shows another side. Through dreams, a fiery furnace and a season of madness, this mighty king met the God of his captives, and his story ends with a letter of praise in his own name. Pride can be broken and still end in worship.

At a glance

Name	Babylonian <i>Nabu-kudurri-usur</i> ; also spelled Nebuchadrezzar
Family	Son of Nabopolassar (from Babylonian records, not the Bible)
Reign	About 43 years, c. 605–562 BC
Capital	Babylon, on the Euphrates River
Key people	Daniel and his three friends; Jehoiachin; Zedekiah; Jeremiah
Main passages	Daniel 1–4; 2 Kings 24–25; 2 Chronicles 36
Successor	Evil-merodach (2 Kings 25:27)
New Testament	Not named

"Now I Nebuchadnezzar praise and extol and honour the King of heaven, all whose works are truth, and his ways judgment: and those that walk in pride he is able to abase."

Daniel 4:37, KJV

The life of Nebuchadnezzar

Dates are approximate (BC). Daniel 1:1 and Jeremiah 25:1 date the first siege a year apart, probably counting years differently. Daniel 3 and 4 give no dates.

c. 605 BC Year he becomes king	● Victory and first captives He defeats Pharaoh Neco at Carchemish, then takes temple vessels and young nobles from Jerusalem, among them Daniel and his friends. <i>Jeremiah 46:2; Daniel 1:1-6</i>
c. 603 BC 2nd year	● The dream of the great image When his wise men cannot tell his dream, he orders them killed. Daniel reveals it, and the king honours Daniel's God. <i>Daniel 2:1-49</i>
Date not given	● The golden image He sets up a golden image on the plain of Dura. Three Jews refuse to bow, survive the furnace, and the king blesses their God. <i>Daniel 3:1-30</i>
c. 597 BC 8th year	● Jehoiachin taken After Jehoiakim rebels, he carries away King Jehoiachin, ten thousand captives and the temple treasures, and makes Zedekiah king. <i>2 Kings 24:1, 10-17</i>
c. 586 BC 19th year	● Jerusalem destroyed Zedekiah rebels. After a long siege the city falls, and Nebuzar-adan burns the temple and breaks down the walls. <i>2 Kings 25:1-11</i>
Later in his reign	● Humbled and restored He boasts of the Babylon he has built and is driven out to live like an animal until he acknowledges that God rules. <i>Daniel 4:28-37</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Babylonian records do not mention the king's madness. Some scholars link Daniel 4 with an old Jewish text about a later king, Nabonidus, who spent years away from Babylon. Others read it as Nebuchadnezzar's own testimony, just as Daniel presents it.

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- 1 Took Jerusalem's best young men.** He besieged Jerusalem, took temple vessels to his god's house, and had noble youths trained in Babylonian learning. *Daniel 1:1-7*

 - 2 Demanded the impossible.** He ordered his wise men to tell him his dream as well as its meaning, and he condemned them all when they could not. *Daniel 2:1-13*

 - 3 Honoured Daniel's God.** After Daniel explained the dream, the king confessed that his God was "a God of gods, and a Lord of kings." *Daniel 2:46-49*

 - 4 Built an idol and a furnace.** He commanded everyone to bow to a golden image. When three Jews refused, he threw them into a furnace heated seven times hotter. *Daniel 3:1-23*

 - 5 Crushed Judah's revolts.** He took Jehoiachin and the temple treasures to Babylon, set up Zedekiah, and finally destroyed the city and temple. *2 Kings 24:10-17; 25:1-10*

 - 6 Spared Jeremiah.** He gave orders that the prophet be treated well and not harmed. *Jeremiah 39:11-12*

 - 7 Fell through pride.** He boasted, "Is not this great Babylon, that I have built," and lost his reason and his throne for a time. *Daniel 4:29-33*

 - 8 Praised the King of heaven.** Restored, he sent a letter to all nations telling what God had done to him. *Daniel 4:1-3, 34-37*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Nebuchadnezzar.

Old Testament

2 Kings 24–25; 2 Chronicles 36:6–21	His campaigns and Jerusalem's fall
Jeremiah 25:9; 27:6	God calls him "my servant," his tool of judgment
Ezekiel 26:7; 29:18–20	"A king of kings" against Tyre; Egypt as wages
Daniel 1–4	His dealings with Daniel and his friends
Daniel 5:18–21	Daniel reminds Belshazzar how he was humbled
Ezra 1:7; 5:12	Cyrus sends back the vessels he took

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:52	"He hath put down the mighty from their seats"
Echo: Revelation 18:2	Babylon, proud human power, falls

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words did Nebuchadnezzar use about himself in Daniel 4:30, and what words did he use about God in Daniel 4:37?
2. *Understand:* Jeremiah calls this pagan king God's "servant" (Jeremiah 27:6). What does that tell us about who is really in charge of history?
3. *Apply:* Nebuchadnezzar praised God after each crisis, then drifted back to pride. Where do you see that same pattern in your own life?
4. *Apply:* What is one success this week that you could thank God for out loud, instead of taking the credit?